Ritam

PARTICIPANT HANDBOOK · ADVANCED COURSE

The Mind in the Light of Modern and Spiritual Sciences

MODULE 2

The Making of the Individual Mind

- 2.1 From Universal Consciousness to the Individual
- 2.2 Structure of the Individual Mind
- 2.3 Ahamkāra: The Formation of “I” and “Mine”
- 2.4 Manas: Processing, Attention and Fluctuation
- 2.5 Buddhi: Determination, Discernment and Meaning
- 2.6 Chitta: Memory, Saṁskāra and Pattern Continuity
- 2.7 How Experience Becomes “Mine”: The Full Loop in Action

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Notation and terms used in Module 2

The symbols and Sanskrit terms the seven lessons use, with the lessons' own wording and the lesson where each first appears. Use it alongside the lesson pages.

Term	In the lessons' words	First appears
localization	Awareness appearing as though centred in one particular body-mind system. By itself it does not yet create bondage.	2.1
limitation; saṅkoca	Trika's saṅkoca, contraction: Consciousness-Energy not diminished in its own nature but contracted in expression.	2.1
identification	The localized and limited standpoint taken to be the whole of oneself: the real beginning of bondage.	2.1
jīva	The individual experiencer, doer, enjoyer and sufferer: Consciousness-Energy as associated with a particular body-mind, then misread as a separate self.	2.1
C∞	Universal Consciousness-Energy, the unbounded source.	2.1 (§7)
P(B-M)	Perspectival centering through a body-mind system.	2.1 (§7)
Λ	Limitation / contraction (saṅkoca).	2.1 (§7)
I	Identification: the localized centre is taken as self.	2.1 (§7)
J	The jīva, the individual experiencer. The lesson's primary sequence: C∞ → P(B-M) → Λ → I → J.	2.1 (§7)
chitta (two senses)	Trika sense (Pratyabhijñā Hṛdayam sūtras 4, 5): Consciousness-Energy in its contracted, individualised mode. Sāṅkhya / Yoga sense, used from 2.2 on: the mind-field, one faculty of the antaḥkaraṇa.	2.1
antaḥkaraṇa	The “inner instrument”, with four principal functions: not the Self, but the instrument through which the Self appears to know, act, and be.	2.1 (explained 2.2)
L_2	The antaḥkaraṇa bandwidth: the field through which experience is received, differentiated, interpreted, personalised and stored.	2.2
manas (L_2a)	The processing mind: fluctuation, comparison, attentional shifting, initial signal handling; the faculty of saṅkalpa and vikalpa.	2.2 (studied 2.4)
buddhi (L_2b)	The discriminative and determinative faculty: discrimination, pattern-resolution, meaning-selection, determination; adhyavasāya, settling.	2.2 (studied 2.5)
ahaṁkāra (L_2c)	The “I”-maker: self-tagging, ownership-binding, doership assignment.	2.2 (studied 2.3)
chitta (L_2d)	The memory-field: retention-field, storage of impression-patterns, latent reactivation.	2.2 (studied 2.6)
saṁskāra	A latent impression left by past experience: not just a memory-image but a stored formative influence.	2.2 (studied 2.6)
vṛtti	An active modification or formation in the mind-field; literally “turning” or “whirlpool”.	2.2 (studied 2.6)
ψ_x	What is actually in front of you (from Lesson 1.1).	2.4
ψ_m	The attention wave manas brings to meet ψ_x (2.4, 2.6). In 1.1 it stood for all you bring; 2.7 separates that into h(t) and ψ_m.	2.4 (completed 2.7)
sattva, rajas, tamas	The three guṇas, buddhi's working condition: clarity, balance; agitation, desire; dullness, inertia, confusion.	2.5
viveka	Buddhi at its highest: discrimination between the real and the unreal, the Self and the not-Self.	2.5
h(t); ψexp(t)	h(t): the current state of the mind-field (the accumulated saṁskāras). ψexp(t): the experienced output. ψexp(t) = f[ψ_x(t), h(t), ψ_m(t)].	2.6 (§5)
chitta-śuddhi	The purification of the mind-field: not erasure, but replacing reactive, fear-based saṁskāras with more luminous ones.	2.6
saṁsāra	The wheel of conditioned existence; the recursive loop is its psychological mechanism: pattern-reinforcement, not punishment.	2.7
sākṣī	The witness: the awareness that sees but is not seen, never itself modified by the loop's content.	2.7

Lesson 2.1: From Universal Consciousness to the Individual

Aim: to understand how one undivided Consciousness-Energy comes to appear as a separate individual through localization, limitation and identification, not as a second reality. **Online:** Practice page and understanding check for 2.1 (vedanta.nz, My Journey).

1 In my own words

In three sentences, say how the universal "I" comes to appear as the personal "I".

2 Terms to recall

Write each in your own words, then check the key points at the back.

Term	In my own words
Localization	
Limitation (saṅkoca)	
Identification	
Jīva	
The true Self	
The sense of self	
Avidyā	
Citta (its two senses)	

3 Fill the gaps

Localization gives a centre. Limitation gives finitude. Identification gives _____.

Consciousness-Energy is not destroyed or diminished in its own nature; it is _____ in expression.

Confusing the true Self with the sense of self is what the traditions call _____.

4 Spot the slip

Each statement contains a mistake. Correct it in the lines below.

"As many individuals, Consciousness-Energy is divided into pieces, and each person has a smaller share."

"Individuality is not ultimate, so it does not matter, and embodied life can be set aside."

Lesson 2.1: From Universal Consciousness to the Individual (continued)

5 Draw it in your own way

Figure 2.1.a. The lesson's caption reads: “Localization, limitation and identification: how one Consciousness-Energy comes to appear as the individual jīva.” In each frame show one movement. The lesson's own images may help: sunlight through a window; a vast field functioning through a finite channel; an actor so absorbed in a role that they forget they are acting. At the foot of each frame write what that movement gives.

1 Localization	2 Limitation	3 Identification
Gives:	Gives:	Gives:

6 Apply

Sam receives a poor mark in a course he cares about and says to a friend, “I am my grades. That is all I am.” Using the lesson's distinction between the true Self and the sense of self, say what the lesson would invite Sam to notice, without denying that his disappointment is real.

7 Tracker

Module 2 follows one thread: how the universal becomes the personal, and what the personal is made of. In one line, note what Lesson 2.1 adds, in the lesson's own words, for example what the lesson says the individual is.

8 Check my notes

Key points for 2.1 are on the page marked 2.1 at the back of the handbook. There are no marks and no self-rating: compare your notes and decide for yourself.

Lesson 2.2: Structure of the Individual Mind

Aim: to understand the antaḥkaraṇa, the inner instrument, as a structured system with four distinguishable functions, and to see how their coordinated operations make experience, memory, identity and bondage possible. **Online:** Practice page and understanding check for 2.2 (vedanta.nz, My Journey).

1 In my own words

In three sentences, say why the lesson holds that "the mind" is not one thing, and what two truths it asks you to hold together about the inner instrument and the Self.

2 Terms to recall

Write each in your own words, then check the key points at the back.

Term	In my own words
Antaḥkaraṇa	
Manas	
Buddhi	
Ahaṁkāra	
Chitta	
Saṁskāra	
Vṛtti	
L_2 bandwidth	

3 Fill the gaps

Where manas wavers, _____ resolves.

The inner instrument is not only a processing system but also a _____ system.

What is cosmic Spanda at the level of manifestation becomes, at the psychological level, _____.

4 Spot the slip

Each statement contains a mistake. Correct it in the lines below.

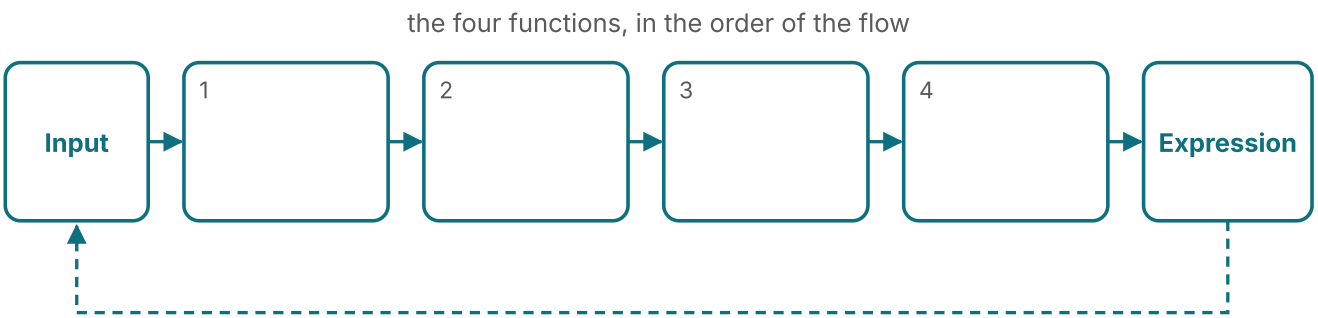
"When I say 'I am anxious', I am describing the Self: the anxiety is what I am."

"Manas, buddhi, ahaṁkāra and chitta are four separate organs, each working on its own."

Lesson 2.2: Structure of the Individual Mind (continued)

5 Complete the figure

Figure 2.2.b. The recursive flow. Input and expression are printed. In the four empty boxes write the four functions in the order of the lesson's flow, and under each name one thing it does. Then, on the line below, say what the arrow running back means.



6 Apply

Ravi sends a friend a long message. A day later she has read it but not replied. He concludes she is upset with him, feels a sting of hurt, and the unease is still there the next morning. In the manner of the lesson's phone example, trace what manas, buddhi, ahaṁkāra and chitta might each be doing in this moment.

7 Tracker

Module 2 follows one thread: how the universal becomes the personal, and what the personal is made of. In one line, note what Lesson 2.2 adds, in the lesson's own words, for example where the lesson places the inner instrument and what it is made of.

8 Check my notes

Key points for 2.2 are on the page marked 2.2 at the back of the handbook. There are no marks and no self-rating: compare your notes and decide for yourself.

Lesson 2.3: Ahamkāra: The Formation of “I” and “Mine”

Aim: to understand how the sense of “I” and “mine” arises within the inner instrument and why it is necessary yet becomes the basis of bondage when mistaken for the Self. **Online:** Practice page and understanding check for 2.3 (vedanta.nz, My Journey).

1 In my own words

In three sentences, say what ahaṁkāra does, and why it is neither the Ātman nor an enemy.

2 Terms to recall

Write each in your own words, then check the key points at the back.

Term	In my own words
Ahaṁkāra	
Self-reference	
Appropriation	
Differentiation	
Asmitā	
Self-tagging layer	
Gain amplifier	
Boundary generator	

3 Fill the gaps

Aham means “I.” Kāra means _____.

The problem is not the size of the ego. It is the _____ of the identification.

Reducing the gain is often more effective than changing the _____.

4 Spot the slip

Each statement contains a mistake. Correct it in the lines below.

“Ego trouble always means inflation: someone who says ‘I am worthless’ is not caught in ahaṁkāra.”

“Once I see clearly that the criticism was fair, my hurt reaction will fall away by itself.”

Lesson 2.3: Ahamkāra: The Formation of “I” and “Mine” (continued)

5 Draw it in your own way

Figure 2.3.b. The lesson's caption reads: “Ahaṁkāra as gain amplifier: the same feedback, claimed tightly or held lightly, produces very different suffering.” Using the lesson's two people at work, show the same feedback entering both frames, and show what comes out of each. Label what is the same and what differs.

Claimed tightly: “I am my work”

Held lightly: “work is something I do, not something I am”

6 Apply

A neighbour mentions to Leah that her hedge has grown over the footpath. Leah spends the evening replaying the remark and telling herself, “They have always looked down on me.” Using the lesson's account of self-tagging, gain and the ways ahaṁkāra can bend the whole instrument, say what may be happening, and what the lesson suggests about the gain.

7 Tracker

Module 2 follows one thread: how the universal becomes the personal, and what the personal is made of. In one line, note what Lesson 2.3 adds, in the lesson's own words, for example the step at which the lesson says experience becomes personal.

8 Check my notes

Key points for 2.3 are on the page marked 2.3 at the back of the handbook. There are no marks and no self-rating: compare your notes and decide for yourself.

Lesson 2.4: Manas: Processing, Attention and Fluctuation

Aim: to understand manas as the coordinating, oscillating and attention-shifting function of the inner instrument, and how, when trained, it becomes a reliable instrument of steady awareness. **Online:** Practice page and understanding check for 2.4 (vedanta.nz, My Journey).

1 In my own words

In three sentences, say what manas does, and how responsive flexibility differs from compulsive scattering.

2 Terms to recall

Write each in your own words, then check the key points at the back.

Term	In my own words
Manas	
Saṅkalpa and vikalpa	
Switching-load	
Disturbance cascade	
Japa	
Ekāgratā (one-pointedness)	
Abhyāsa	
Vairāgya	

3 Fill the gaps

In the L_2 bandwidth model, manas occupies the _____ position.

Forcing the mind to be still is like holding the surface of _____ flat with your hands.

Over time, as practice deepens, manas becomes responsive without being _____.

4 Spot the slip

Each statement contains a mistake. Correct it in the lines below.

"When I multitask, my mind really does two things at once, at no extra cost."

"Japa, posture and breath regulation are beginner exercises, left behind in real meditation."

Lesson 2.4: Manas: Processing, Attention and Fluctuation (continued)

5 Draw it in your own way

Figure 2.4.b. The lesson's caption reads: “The disturbance cascade: scattered manas leads to weak discrimination, reactive selfing and reinforced disturbance in chitta.” In the frame, show the cascade as the lesson describes it, starting from high-noise input and passing through manas, buddhi, ahaṁkāra and chitta. Then mark with a star the point where the lesson says the first intervention should target.

The disturbance cascade

6 Apply

Tom checks his phone in bed each morning: messages, headlines, updates. By breakfast he feels overwhelmed and unable to think clearly, though nothing specific is wrong, and he wonders whether something is deeply amiss with his life. Using the lesson, say where such a feeling often begins, and what the lesson suggests as a first step.

7 Tracker

Module 2 follows one thread: how the universal becomes the personal, and what the personal is made of. In one line, note what Lesson 2.4 adds, in the lesson's own words, for example where in the inner instrument the lesson says what you bring (ψ_m) first enters.

8 Check my notes

Key points for 2.4 are on the page marked 2.4 at the back of the handbook. There are no marks and no self-rating: compare your notes and decide for yourself.

Lesson 2.5: Buddhi: Determination, Discernment and Meaning

Aim: to understand buddhi as the determinative and discriminative faculty: it resolves the oscillation of manas into definite knowledge, assigns meaning, and governs the inner system. **Online:** Practice page and understanding check for 2.5 (vedanta.nz, My Journey).

1 In my own words

In three sentences, say what buddhi does with the output of manas, and why it sits in the charioteer's seat.

2 Terms to recall

Write each in your own words, then check the key points at the back.

Term	In my own words
Buddhi	
Adhyavasāya	
The charioteer	
Sattva	
Rajas	
Tamas	
Viveka	
Buddhi-yoga	

3 Fill the gaps

In each case, buddhi is doing three things: resolving uncertainty, assigning _____, and directing action.

Spiritual growth is not the acquisition of something you do not have; it is the _____ of the medium.

With CBT, the lesson holds that it is not events that cause suffering, but the _____ we place on them.

4 Spot the slip

Each statement contains a mistake. Correct it in the lines below.

"Buddhi is simply one of the four functions, with no more weight than the other three."

"If my buddhi is clever, strategic and effective, it must be sāttvic."

Lesson 2.5: Buddhi: Determination, Discernment and Meaning (continued)

5 Draw it in your own way

Figure 2.5.c. The lesson's caption reads: “The three guṇas of buddhi: sattva reflects the Self clearly, rajas fragments the reflection, tamas darkens it entirely.” Using Vivekananda's image of the lake and the full moon, draw the reflection as each guṇa leaves it, and under each frame write one phrase from the lesson for what the charioteer is doing.

Sattva	Rajas	Tamas

6 Apply

Ravi's manager sends him a two-line message: “Can we talk tomorrow? Nothing urgent.” By evening Ravi has settled it: “I am going to lose my job.” Using the lesson's three things buddhi does, say what buddhi has determined here, which of the distortions the lesson lists fits his determination, and what a more balanced interpretation might be. Do not describe yourself.

7 Tracker

Module 2 follows one thread: how the universal becomes the personal, and what the personal is made of. Write one line on what Lesson 2.5 adds, in the lesson's own words.

8 Check my notes

Key points for 2.5 are on the page marked 2.5 at the back of the handbook. There are no marks and no self-rating: compare your notes and decide for yourself.

Lesson 2.6: Chitta: Memory, Saṁskāra and Pattern Continuity

Aim: to understand chitta as the retentive dimension of the inner instrument, and how it keeps the past active in the present. **Online:** Practice page and understanding check for 2.6 (vedanta.nz, My Journey).

1 In my own words

In three sentences, relate chitta, saṁskāra and vṛtti, and say why the past stays active.

2 Terms to recall

Write each in your own words, then check the key points at the back.

Term	In my own words
Chitta	
Saṁskāra	
Vṛtti	
Citta-vṛtti-nirodha	
h(t)	
Pattern-continuity loop	
Holographic principle	
Chitta-śuddhi	

3 Fill the gaps

Chitta is the field, saṁskāra is the seed, and vṛtti is the _____ that grows from the seed.

A saṁskāra is not just a memory-image. It is a stored _____ influence.

Without conscious intervention, the default direction is toward _____.

4 Spot the slip

Each statement contains a mistake. Correct it in the lines below.

"Purifying the mind-field means erasing chitta."

"Once I see that my reaction is out of proportion, the pattern should simply stop."

Lesson 2.6: Chitta: Memory, Saṁskāra and Pattern Continuity (continued)

5 Draw it in your own way

Figure 2.6.b. The lesson's caption reads: “The pattern-continuity loop: activated impressions strengthen and stronger impressions activate more easily.” Draw the full cycle as a loop, in the lesson's seven steps, starting from “Experience” and coming back round to a strengthened impression. Use any picture you like (a riverbed, a groove, a circle), and label every step.

The pattern-continuity loop

6 Apply

As a child, Leila was laughed at whenever she stumbled reading aloud in class. Now an adult, she feels her face burn when she is asked to read the minutes at a meeting, though no one laughs. Using the lesson's words, say what chitta has retained, why her reaction may feel larger than the situation, and which practices the lesson says work at this level. Keep the lesson's point that this is not a personal failure. Do not describe yourself.

7 Tracker

Module 2 follows one thread: how the universal becomes the personal, and what the personal is made of. Write one line on what Lesson 2.6 adds, in the lesson's own words.

8 Check my notes

Key points for 2.6 are on the page marked 2.6 at the back of the handbook. There are no marks and no self-rating: compare your notes and decide for yourself.

Lesson 2.7: How Experience Becomes “Mine”: The Full Loop in Action

Aim: to see the four functions working as one system, why the loop reinforces itself, and that awareness can observe the whole loop. **Online:** Practice page and understanding check for 2.7 (vedanta.nz, My Journey).

1 In my own words

In three sentences, say what “my experience” is in this lesson's terms, and who is watching when you trace the loop.

2 Terms to recall

Write each in your own words, then check the key points at the back.

Term	In my own words
The forward flow	
The loop closes	
Recursive feedback loop	
Saṁsāra	
Ψ_x	
Ψ_m	
Sākṣī	
The rider	

3 Fill the gaps

Buddhi's determination is not a free choice made in the present. It is a _____ response.

The recursive loop is the psychological mechanism of what the traditions call _____.

What you bring is the accumulated output of the inner instrument's processing over a _____.

4 Spot the slip

Each statement contains a mistake. Correct it in the lines below.

“Saṁsāra is a punishment handed out for past mistakes.”

“To be free of the loop, I would have to stop being a person and give up my life.”

Lesson 2.7: How Experience Becomes "Mine" (continued)

5 Draw it in your own way

Figure 2.7.b. The lesson's caption reads: "What you bring is made of: the attentional, interpretive, self-referential and stored patterns of the whole instrument." Draw ψ_x meeting what you bring, and unpack what you bring into its four parts, naming the function each comes from.

ψ_x meets what you bring

6 Apply

At lunch, Sione's colleague says, "Interesting choice of project." Sione replays it all evening. Trace the moment through the lesson's five steps, a few words each, then name one place where, in the lesson's words, he could observe the loop without being caught in it. Do not describe yourself.

7 Tracker

Gather the module's thread: how the universal becomes the personal, and what the personal is made of. For each lesson, write a few words on what it added, in the lesson's own words.

Lesson	What it added to the thread
2.1 From Universal Consciousness to the Individual	
2.2 Structure of the Individual Mind	
2.3 Ahaṁkāra: The Formation of "I" and "Mine"	
2.4 Manas: Processing, Attention and Fluctuation	
2.5 Buddhi: Determination, Discernment and Meaning	
2.6 Chitta: Memory, Saṁskāra and Pattern Continuity	

8 Check my notes

Key points for 2.7 are on the page marked 2.7 at the back of the handbook. There are no marks and no self-rating: compare your notes and decide for yourself.

2.1 From Universal Consciousness to the Individual

Key points, not model answers. Compare them with your own notes and add what you missed in another colour.

The main ideas

- The universal “I” becomes the personal “I” through three linked movements, structural features of how individuality is maintained in every moment, not events of the past. They are movements within dynamic Consciousness-Energy itself: nothing inert shrinks down into a person.
- Localization: awareness appears as though centred in one body-mind. Like sunlight through a window, it seems to be “here”, yet the sun has not been divided. By itself it does not yet create bondage.
- Limitation: in Trika, saṅkoca, contraction. Consciousness-Energy is contracted in expression, not diminished in nature. It makes finite experience possible, and makes the individual feel vulnerable.
- Identification: the localized, limited standpoint is taken to be the whole of oneself, like an actor who forgets they are acting. This is the emergence of the jīva and the real beginning of bondage. Localization gives a centre, limitation finitude, identification ownership.
- The true Self is ontological, what you truly are; the sense of self is experiential and functional, what you take yourself to be. The individual “I” is the universal “I” wearing a costume. Confusing the two is avidyā; distinguishing them is the beginning of liberation.
- Sri Ramakrishna: Brahman and Śakti are not two, like fire and its power to burn; Trika says Prakāśa and Vimarśa. Hence the term Consciousness-Energy.
- Pratyabhijñā Hṛdayam: the individual is the whole universe in contracted form, as a tree is present within a seed (sūtra 4); Citi, contracting in relation to objects, becomes citta (sūtra 5). Trika citta is the whole contracted being; the Sāṅkhya / Yoga citta, used from 2.2 on, is one faculty of the antaḥkaraṇa.
- Science shows how a personal perspective is assembled (boundary, embodied perspective, sensory integration, memory, self-representation, narrative, agency) but usually stops at structure and process.
- Harmonised view: individuality is experientially real, psychologically necessary, biologically supported, socially reinforced and metaphysically non-ultimate. It avoids crude pluralism and vague monism. The lesson's summary line is C∞ → P(B-M) → Λ → I → J; like one sun in many pots, the light is not divided.

Terms

Localization	Awareness appearing as though centred in one particular body-mind system.
Limitation (saṅkoca)	Contraction: a vast self-expressive field functioning through a finite channel.
Identification	The localized and limited standpoint taken to be the whole of oneself.
Jīva	The individual experiencer, doer, enjoyer and sufferer.
True Self and sense of self	What you truly are; the constructed, conditioned “I” of everyday life.
Avidyā	Not lack of information but a fundamental misreading of one's own nature.

Answers to the exercises

- **Gaps:** ownership; contracted; avidyā.
- **Slips:** Consciousness-Energy is not divided; limitation is not division (“You are limited, but you are not cut off”); individuality is real and necessary, though non-ultimate, and dismissing it is what the lesson calls vague monism.
- **Figure:** look for a centre made in one place without the source being divided (localization, gives a centre); a channel narrower than the source (limitation, gives finitude); the formation taken as the whole (identification, gives ownership: “happening to me”). Together they yield the jīva.

Draft for author review: wording is taken from the lesson text; the figure task is a free frame; the notation line follows §7.2.

2.2 Structure of the Individual Mind

Key points, not model answers. Compare them with your own notes and add what you missed in another colour.

The main ideas

- "The mind" is not one thing: its activities can work at cross purposes. The antaḥkaraṇa has four principal functions, not four separate organs but four modes of functioning within one instrument, like currents at different depths in one river. In any moment all four are typically active.
- The instrument is not the Self. "I am anxious" describes, strictly, a state of the antaḥkaraṇa; the Self is the awareness in which anxiety appears and is known. The anxiety is real, but not the whole of who you are.
- Vivekananda's correction: body, mind and Self are not three things but one Existence, called body, mind or Self according to different vision. The distinction is a teaching tool, not the final truth; hold both.
- The antaḥkaraṇa is the L_2 bandwidth, the bridge-band between embodied life and higher knowing, with sub-bands L_2a manas, L_2b buddhi, L_2c ahaṁkāra, L_2d chitta.
- Manas receives and oscillates (saṅkalpa and vikalpa), like radar; buddhi resolves and assigns meaning (adhyavasāya); ahaṁkāra claims experience as "I" and "mine"; chitta retains impressions and saṁskāras.
- The functions run as one coordinated, recursive flow. What chitta retains shapes how manas attends, how buddhi interprets and how ahaṁkāra claims next time: the instrument is also a conditioning system.
- The chariot (Kaṭhopaniṣad): body as chariot, Ātman as rider, buddhi as charioteer, manas as reins, senses as horses. When the reins are slack, even a clear buddhi cannot govern.
- Cosmic Spanda appears in the individual as vṛtti. Mental activity is not random noise; yoga is not about stopping the mind but seeing through the waves to the depth they arise from.
- Bondage begins when recurrent patterns are misread as the Self. Liberation runs the other way, through awareness that observes the loop: not all at once, not easily. The model asks which function is disturbed, and what it needs.

Terms

Antaḥkaraṇa	The inner instrument: one structured system with four functions.
Manas and buddhi	The processing mind that wavers; the discriminative faculty that determines and assigns meaning.
Ahaṁkāra and chitta	The "I"-maker that claims experience; the memory-field that retains impressions.
Saṁskāra	A deep impression left by experience, emotion and action, shaping from below the surface.
Vṛtti	An active modification or formation in the mind-field; literally "turning" or "whirlpool".
L_2 bandwidth	The place of the antaḥkaraṇa in the spectrum, between gross body and higher intelligence.

Answers to the exercises

- **Gaps:** buddhi; conditioning; vṛtti.
- **Slips:** anxiety is, strictly, a state of the antaḥkaraṇa, and the Self is the awareness in which it appears and is known; the four are modes of functioning within one inner instrument, typically all active together.
- **Figure:** manas (gathers, compares, presents), buddhi (determines meaning), ahaṁkāra (appropriates as "I" and "mine"), chitta (stores the trace). The arrow back: the flow is recursive, so what is retained shapes the next moment.

Draft for author review: wording is taken from the lesson text. The flow drawing in task 5 is the handbook's own simple line art, not the lesson's Figure 2.2.b.

2.3 Ahamkāra: The Formation of “I” and “Mine”

Key points, not model answers. Compare them with your own notes and add what you missed in another colour.

The main ideas

- Ahaṁkāra, the “I-maker”, generates “I am the doer”, “I am the experiencer” and “this is mine” through three operations: self-reference (centering), appropriation (claiming) and differentiation (boundary-drawing).
- It is not the Ātman. Ahaṁkāra is contingent, shifting and dependent on feedback from the world. The tragedy of ignorance is not that the Self disappears but that ahaṁkāra takes its place in lived awareness.
- Sāṅkhya: the principle of individuation, downstream of buddhi. Vedānta: neti, neti discriminates the Self from its formations. Yoga: asmitā confuses the power of seeing with the instrument of seeing. Trika: Consciousness-Energy as a localised claimant, not wholly false, so not to be hated but seen through.
- It is necessary: responsibility, relationship, learning and ethics need a working “I”. It becomes destructive when rigid and absolute, when the functional “I” becomes the metaphysical “I”. The problem is not the experience but its appropriation: rain is just rain until ahaṁkāra says “my picnic is ruined”.
- A timid ego (“I am worthless”) is as much ahaṁkāra as a grandiose one (“I am superior”): the same function on different content.
- Self-tagging layer: after manas and buddhi, ahaṁkāra tags content as “mine”; the tagging step is where experience becomes personal. Gain amplifier (a Module 2 modelling image): tightly claimed content is amplified. Boundary generator: useful boundaries, or an over-hardened fortress.
- Recursive loops deepen grooves; the same mechanism in reverse can create different ones. Ahaṁkāra can also bend the whole instrument: selective attention, interpretive bias, narrative fixation and defensive filtering. Insight alone is often insufficient.
- Harmonised view: the ego is a provisional organising structure, not an enemy. Growth reorders identity around a deeper centre; it does not annihilate functional individuality. The problem is that the practical “I” becomes metaphysical.

Terms

Ahaṁkāra	The “I-maker”: aham, “I”, and kāra, “maker”.
Appropriation	Claiming thoughts, actions, emotions, roles and possessions as “mine”.
Differentiation	Separating self from other, mine from not-mine: drawing the boundary of identity.
Asmitā	In the Yoga Sūtras, the “I-am-ness” that confuses the power of seeing with the instrument of seeing.
Gain amplifier	The degree to which self-tagged content is amplified, depending on how tightly it is claimed.
Defensive filtering	Ahaṁkāra overriding even clear buddhi-discrimination when identity feels threatened.

Answers to the exercises

- **Gaps:** “maker”; absoluteness; content.
- **Slips:** a timid ego that says “I am worthless” is as much ahaṁkāra as a grandiose one, and the problem is the absoluteness of the identification, not the size of the ego; through defensive filtering ahaṁkāra can stop that knowing from reaching you emotionally, so insight alone is often insufficient.
- **Figure:** the feedback is the same in both frames; what differs is the gain. Claimed tightly, praise becomes inflation and criticism injury; held lightly, it is received as useful information, processed and let go.

Draft for author review: wording is taken from the lesson text; the figure task is a free frame because the printed Figure 2.3.b was not reproduced.

2.4 Manas: Processing, Attention and Fluctuation

Key points, not model answers. Compare them with your own notes and add what you missed in another colour.

The main ideas

- The Vedāntasāra defines manas by saṅkalpa and vikalpa: forming notions, weighing alternatives, doubting and wavering. Manas is not the whole mind; it presents alternatives before clearer determination arises in buddhi.
- Manas is like a radar: it scans, shifts, compares and flags what seems salient. This scanning is not a defect but biologically necessary. The difference lies between responsive flexibility, which serves life, and compulsive scattering, which fragments it.
- Manas tends toward extroversion unless trained. The modern environment is engineered to capture it.
- When manas is chronically scattered, everything downstream suffers: buddhi cannot discriminate clearly, ahaṁkāra becomes reactive, and chitta stores shallow, fragmented impressions.
- Manas occupies L_2a, the first stage of the processing chain. Disturbances that seem emotional or existential often begin with attentional overload, so the first intervention should target manas.
- Manas is where what you bring (ψ_m) first enters the meeting with ψ_x: by selecting and comparing, it has already shaped experience before it reaches buddhi.
- Science: attention is limited; switching has a cost, so multitasking is largely an illusion; novelty and threat capture attention; sustained attention takes effort; attention shapes perception.
- Japa, posture, breath regulation, solitude and silence, and one-pointedness are targeted interventions at the manas level. Each reduces the switching-load; japa functions like a reference rhythm the system can lock onto.
- These are foundational, not preliminary exercises to be outgrown. Manas is trainable, not by suppression but, as the Gītā says, through abhyāsa and vairāgya. Trained manas is responsive without being reactive.

Terms

Saṅkalpa and vikalpa	Forming notions and weighing alternatives; proposing and doubting.
Switching-load	The burden of attention shifting between many competing signals.
Disturbance cascade	Scattered manas leading to weak discrimination, reactive selfing and reinforced disturbance in chitta.
Japa	Repetition of a sacred name or mantra: one steady object for manas to return to.
Ekāgratā	One-pointedness: the ability to choose where attention rests and to maintain that choice.
Abhyāsa and vairāgya	Persistent practice; dispassion, a loosening of the compulsive pull of objects.

Answers to the exercises

- **Gaps:** L_2a; water; reactive.
- **Slips:** the mind is not doing two things at once but rapidly switching between them, paying a cost at every transition; these practices are foundational disciplines that support everything else, not exercises to be outgrown.
- **Figure:** look for a chain from high-noise input through excessive switching, poor filtering and an unstable foreground, to weak discrimination (buddhi), reactive selfing (ahaṁkāra) and reinforced disturbance in chitta. The star belongs at manas: stabilising the input-processing layer itself.

Draft for author review: wording is taken from the lesson text; the figure task is a free frame because the printed Figure 2.4.b was not reproduced. The breaths-per-minute figure in §6 is not used.

2.5 Buddhi: Determination, Discernment and Meaning

Key points, not model answers. Compare them with your own notes and add what you missed in another colour.

The main ideas

- In Sāṅkhya, buddhi is defined by adhyavasāya: settling, determining, making definite. Where manas oscillates, buddhi resolves: this is what it is, what it means, what to do. The meaning it assigns is not neutral: it shapes the whole downstream response.
- In the Kaṭhopaniṣad's chariot, the Self is the rider, buddhi the charioteer, manas the reins, the senses the horses. Buddhi is not one function among four but the governing function.
- Vivekananda's lake: calm water reflects the Self (the full moon) clearly. His glass globe: the same light is in each; what differs is the clarity of the glass. Growth is purifying the medium, and no one is beyond hope.
- The guṇas set buddhi's working condition. Sāttvic: sharp discrimination. Rājasic: driven by craving, clever but unwise. Tāmasic: unable to discriminate; not the acceptance of wisdom. Practices that increase sattva improve judgment.
- At its highest, buddhi is the seat of viveka. In the Gītā's buddhi-yoga, Krishna does not tell Arjuna to suppress his doubts; he teaches him to see clearly, and right action follows.
- The lesson reads the Davy story, as Vivekananda recounted it, as subtler perception glimpsed when the grosser layers quieted: the solid world is not a lie but a partial reading.
- Buddhi is the L_2b band. A single misinterpretation can be tagged by ahaṁkāra, stored in chitta, and become a filter for hundreds of future experiences.
- CBT converges: it is not events but the interpretations placed on them. Catastrophising, black-and-white thinking, personalising, mind-reading and overgeneralising are, in the course's language, buddhi-level distortions; the traditions add discrimination of the Self from the not-Self.

Terms

Adhyavasāya	The act of settling, determining, making definite.
Sattva, rajas, tamas	Clarity and balance; agitation and desire; dullness and inertia.
Viveka	Discrimination between the real and the unreal, the Self and the not-Self.
Buddhi-yoga	The yoga of discernment: clarify buddhi, and the rest of the system comes into order.
L_2b	The discrimination-and-determination band within the antaḥkaraṇa bandwidth.

Answers to the exercises

- **Gaps:** meaning; purification; interpretations.
- **Slips:** buddhi is not just one function among four but the governing function, the charioteer whose clarity decides whether the whole system is coherent or chaotic. Cleverness is not proof of sattva: rājasic buddhi still functions and can be clever, strategic and effective, yet it assigns meaning toward desire rather than truth (“intelligent but unwise”).
- **Figure task:** a clear moon in still water (sattva), a broken reflection (rajas), a darkened one (tamas); phrases such as “fully alert”, “distracted by the scenery”, “fallen asleep at the reins”.
- **Apply:** buddhi has resolved an ambiguous message into “this is what it is” and “this is what it means”; the fit is catastrophising (assuming the worst possible outcome). A more balanced reading might be: “My manager wants to talk; I do not yet know about what.”

Draft for author review: wording is taken from the lesson text; the figure task is a free frame because the printed figure was not reproduced. Ravi's case is the handbook's own example. The §8 line on manas-level and buddhi-level problems is not used in the exercises.

2.6 Chitta: Memory, Saṁskāra and Pattern Continuity

Key points, not model answers. Compare them with your own notes and add what you missed in another colour.

The main ideas

- Chitta is the retentive or store-bearing aspect of the mind, the subtle field in which experience leaves traces: like a riverbed, shaped by what has flowed through it and shaping how future water flows.
- A saṁskāra is a latent impression left by past experience, thought, feeling or action. Repetition and emotional intensity strengthen it. It does not merely record what happened; it shapes what happens next (the criticised child, the practised musician, the meditator).
- Chitta is the field, saṁskāra the seed, vṛtti the plant. Present experience stirs saṁskāras, which rise as vṛttis, which leave new saṁskāras. Citta-vṛtti-nirodha is the stilling of the active formations, not the destruction of chitta.
- The past does not vanish when it is no longer conscious. This helps explain persistent fears, reactions out of proportion, repeating cycles, and why insight alone is often insufficient: the saṁskāra works at a deeper level than conscious thought.
- In the systems model, $\psi exp(t) = f[\psi_x(t), h(t), \psi_m(t)]$: experience depends on what is happening, on the accumulated state of the mind-field, and on attention, so the same input gives different outputs in different mind-fields.
- The loop: experience → impression → retention → reactivation → tendency → repeated action → strengthened impression. Without conscious intervention the default is reinforcement.
- Pribram's holonomic model is a suggestive bridge, not a proven theory. Read with Pratyabhijñā Hṛdayam sūtra 4 and the Gītā, it suggests each impression carries the quality of the whole field: one deep saṁskāra can colour a personality; one moment of genuine insight can begin to transform the field.
- Chitta is not negative: it is the basis of both bondage and growth. Chitta-śuddhi is not erasure but the gradual replacement of reactive, fear-based saṁskāras with clearer, more luminous ones: slow, but profound and lasting.
- The lesson frames anxiety loops, trauma residue, compulsive habits and depressive interpretations not as personal failures but as retained patterns that can be understood and gradually transformed.

Terms

Vṛtti	The active formation that arises when stored impressions are stirred.
h(t)	The current state of the mind-field: the accumulated saṁskāras.
ψexp(t)	The experienced output: what you actually think, feel or perceive.
Chitta-śuddhi	The purification of the mind-field: replacing, not erasing.

Answers to the exercises

- **Gaps:** plant; formative; reinforcement.
- **Slips:** chitta-śuddhi does not mean erasing chitta, which would erase learning, skill and growth along with the painful patterns; it means gradually replacing reactive saṁskāras with clearer ones. Insight alone is often insufficient, because the saṁskāra is embedded in the field itself, not just in the surface mind.
- **Figure task:** look for all seven steps in the lesson's order, with the last step feeding back into the first; any picture that shows the loop closing is fine.
- **Apply:** a saṁskāra of shame around stumbling; the small situation has activated a large stored pattern; japa, meditation, vigilance, discrimination, service and the study of sacred texts gradually reshape the field.

Draft for author review: wording is taken from the lesson text; the figure task is a free frame because the printed figure was not reproduced. Leila's case is the handbook's own example. The Gītā verses are not quoted here.

2.7 How Experience Becomes “Mine”: The Full Loop in Action

Key points, not model answers. Compare them with your own notes and add what you missed in another colour.

The main ideas

- One ordinary moment, an ambiguous remark at a family gathering, is traced through the whole instrument: manas detects and orients; buddhi interprets and assigns meaning; ahaṁkāra claims and amplifies; chitta stores the impression; the loop closes.
- Buddhi resolves the way it has been conditioned to resolve. A different buddhi, less primed by old patterns, might hear “She is worried about me.”
- In replay the loop runs on stored material, without any new input. At the next meeting chitta's impressions bias manas, prime buddhi and sensitise ahaṁkāra: the impression has become a filter.
- The cycle is recursive. It is the psychological mechanism of saṁsāra: not a punishment, not a cosmic conspiracy, but pattern-reinforcement operating automatically unless awareness intervenes.
- What you bring is the accumulated output of the instrument over a lifetime: the attentional biases of manas, the habitual interpretations of buddhi, the self-referential patterns of ahaṁkāra and the saṁskāras stored in chitta. It is not one thing but the whole conditioned system, so changing it requires sustained practice, not just momentary insight.
- In Lesson 1.1 ψ_m stood for all of this at once; the wave model of Modules 3 and 4 separates it into h(t), the saṁskāras stored in chitta, and ψ_m proper, the attention wave that manas brings.
- Who was doing the watching? The witness, the sākṣī: aware of the whole process without being caught in it, never itself modified by the loop's content. In the chariot, this is the rider, the Ātman.
- The instrument is not a second Reality: it is the Self as perceived through the medium of the mind. Recognition does not require you to stop being a person. It begins with the capacity to observe the loop; each time you do, you are resting, even briefly, as the awareness the loop has been obscuring.

Terms

Recursive feedback loop	The output of each cycle feeds back into the input of the next.
Saṁsāra	The wheel of conditioned existence; here, its psychological mechanism.
ψ_x and ψ_m	What is actually in front of you; what you bring to it.
Sākṣī	The witness: the awareness that sees but is not seen.

Answers to the exercises

- **Gaps:** conditioned; saṁsāra; lifetime.
- **Slips:** saṁsāra is not a punishment or a cosmic conspiracy but pattern-reinforcement operating automatically within the inner instrument. Recognition does not require you to stop being a person or to abandon your life; it begins simply with the capacity to observe the loop.
- **Figure task:** what you bring, unpacked into the attentional biases of manas, the habitual interpretations of buddhi, the self-referential patterns of ahaṁkāra and the saṁskāras stored in chitta, meeting ψ_x.
- **Apply:** manas snaps to the remark; buddhi resolves it (for example, “He thinks my project is foolish”); ahaṁkāra claims it; chitta stores it; replay closes the loop. One place: to notice buddhi's interpretation without accepting it as final truth.
- **Tracker:** 2.1 localization, limitation, identification, and the jīva; 2.2 one inner instrument with four functions, not the Self; 2.3 the “I”-maker; 2.4 manas detects and compares; 2.5 buddhi determines meaning; 2.6 chitta retains.

Draft for author review: wording is taken from the lesson text; the figure task is a free frame. Sione's case is the handbook's own example. The closing note on three functions is not used.